



Take One, Ring Nobody

A Census of 4,912 Leaflets in 34 Waiting Rooms Against a Reach Indicator Built From Restocking Volume

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The problem

A waiting-room rack is refilled when it empties, and the refill is reported as reach. Nobody re-reads what sits in the pockets. How much of a full rack still points somewhere, and would the indicator notice if it did not?

Objectives

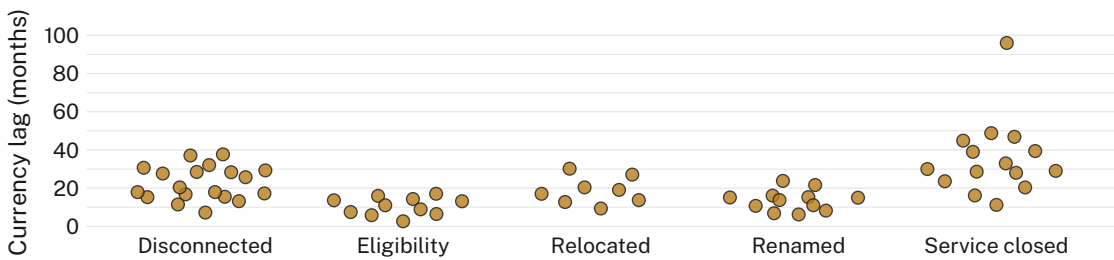
- Catalogue what is on the rack, not what a service says it distributes
- Classify how a leaflet stops being current, and how long it stays after
- Test whether a restocking target changes what a rack holds

Materials & methods

- 34 suburban medical centres · 61 racks · 3 visits each · 12 weeks · 4,912 leaflets · 268 distinct titles
- Two coders classified every title against a five-mode currency framework — service closed, number disconnected, programme renamed, eligibility superseded, address relocated ($\kappa = 0.84$)
- Every contact number rung once and every address checked once; mode definitions and the closed-service test pre-registered, none adjusted post hoc

Results

Racks are full and partly obsolete. 64 of 268 distinct titles (23.9%) fail at least one currency test, accounting for 1,118 leaflets on the shelf. Median currency lag is 19 months (IQR 7–41). 61.3% of titles carry no date or version marker at all.



Currency lag by failure mode, 64 non-current titles (three rack visits, March–May 2026). One closed-service leaflet had been in the pocket 96 months; all 61 racks were fully stocked at every visit.

What it means

Reach is measured on the wrong event: a refill counts a leaflet leaving the rack, not the service behind it still standing. A rack of dead titles reports as well as a live one.

A restocking target changes nothing here. Centres reporting against one held 28.4% non-current titles against 26.9% without (difference 1.5 percentage points, 95% CI –6.2 to 9.2). The target moves volume, not content.

Next: whether a printed review date shortens the lag, or only relocates the audit.

Selected references

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Titles and rack positions only; no room counted while occupied. Mode definitions pre-registered.

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“Every rack was full at every visit.”

23.9% of the titles on them pointed to a closed service, a number that no longer connects, or an address that had moved.